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A Tale of Three Sisters: Language Ideologies, Identities, and Negotiations in a Bilingual, Transnational Family

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A Tale of Three Sisters: Language Ideologies, Identities, and Negotiations in a Bilingual, Transnational Family

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This longitudinal case study investigated how linguistic identity was constructed, constrained, and performed by three sisters, aged 1, 12, and 17, within one bilingual, transnational Ecuadorian–U.S. family. Data were collected over 14 months through weekly home visits that included participant observation, informal interviews, and family-generated audio-recordings of home conversations. Ethnographically informed discourse analysis of family interactions and interviews examined how each of the three daughters was positioned and positioned herself discursively as a language learner and user, and how locally held ideologies about language and language learning shaped the ways in which identities and family roles were constructed and enacted. These findings sharpen our understanding of how widely circulating discourses and ideologies of language—and ideologies of language learning in particular—shape family language practices as well as children's ascribed and prescribed identities within the large and growing number of transnational families in the United States and beyond.

Keywords: language ideology, identity, bilingualism, sibling, transnationalism, Ecuador

INTRODUCTION

Although language shift is most often characterized as a societal-level phenomenon (Dorian, 1981; Gal, 1979), it is best understood as the collective outcome of many individual, family-internal decisions and practices. The complexity of this familial decision-making process and related language practices has been documented across multiple fields. Anthropologists have illustrated how culture-specific beliefs about language and child-rearing variably influence language socialization patterns (Ochs & Schieffelin, 1984). Linguists have demonstrated how parental discourse strategies account for the varied success of bilingual parenting efforts (Lanza, 1997), and sociolinguists have stressed the critical role of intergenerational transmission in modeling language loss (Fishman, 1966) and language revitalization (Fishman, 1991). In turn, language policy scholars have attempted to integrate work from across these lines of research under the rubric of *family language policy* (King & Fogle, 2013; King, Fogle, & Logan-Terry, 2008), which they define as the study of *language ideologies* (how family members think about

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language), *language practices* (what they do with language), and *language management* (what they try to do with language).

Across much of this work, three trends represent substantial advances and, concomitantly, ongoing challenges. First, recent efforts have attempted to untangle the interplay between family-internal (sometimes described as micro) and family-external (macro or structural) forces. Because the family unit is "porous, open to influences and interests from other broader social forces and institutions" (Canagarajah, 2008, p. 171), of interest is how broadly circulating language ideologies shape decision-making and language use patterns in homes (King, 2000). Language ideology, taken here as the cultural systems "of ideas about social and linguistic relationships, together with their loading of moral and political interests" (Irvine, 1989, p. 255), embodies both collective perceptions and cultural hegemonies (Gal, 1998). A crucial question for researchers, then, is precisely how and in what ways these ideologies and their attendant discourses shape, and are enacted within, family language practices.

Ample work has focused on how parental language choices are shaped by attitudes and ideologies surrounding particular languages. For instance, Canagarajah's (2008) study of Tamil-speaking families illustrated how the positive value of English, together with the desire to overcome caste inequalities and pressure to join the mainstream, overwhelmed parental Tamil maintenance efforts. Although it is well established that the assumed value of national or official languages can undermine family efforts to maintain minority languages (e.g., Patrick, 2003), far less is known about how ideologies of language learning impact family language practices. For example, many (monolingual) communities believe that simultaneous exposure to two languages results in language delay or developmental problems (King & Fogle, 2006; Okita, 2001), despite substantial evidence to the contrary (Baker, 2006). Concomitantly, second language learning for youth and adolescents is often assumed incorrectly to be a quick (e.g., 1- to 2-year) process resulting in balanced bilingualism, with pace of language learning among immigrants often taken as a proxy for individual/group success (Blackledge, 2002). Though these ideologies of language learning are in broad circulation, detailed analysis of how they interact with family language practices is absent.

A second area of ongoing work examines the critical role of children's agency in shaping parental language use. Though early language socialization research tended to focus on the role of caretakers in socializing their children *to* and *through* language to culture-specific norms (Garrett & Baquedano-López, 2002), recent work emphasizes children as active participants in socializing their parents to language practices (e.g., Tuominen, 1999). Fogle (2012), for instance, in her study of school-age, Russian-speaking children adopted into English-speaking families, illustrated how children are powerful agents in shaping parental language input patterns according to their preferences and learning needs. Yet Fogle's (2012) work, like much of the research on family language socialization in multilingual contexts, focuses on interactions between generations—that is, between parents and children or, less frequently, between grandparents and children (see Park, 2008)—with the aim of highlighting cross-generational patterns and differences. With few exceptions (e.g., Howard, 2007; Paugh, 2005; Reynolds, 2009), much less attention has been paid to variation *within* one family generation. Although there is strong evidence that important differences exist among siblings (Obied, 2009; Shin, 2002), the role of siblings is "an almost unexplored territory" in bilingual studies (Baker, 2006, p. 63).

A third body of work draws on studies of transnationalism to critique the assumptions of early models of (family) language shift. Transnational approaches seek to analyze "how everyday

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practices of ordinary people produce cultural meanings that sustain transnational networks and make possible enduring translocal ties" (Glick Schiller, Basch, & Blanc-Szanton, 1992, p. 7). Because the lives of a growing number of individuals cannot be understood by looking only at experiences and events within national boundaries (Levitt & Glick Schiller, 2004), transnational research highlights "the systems or relationships that span two or more nations, including sustained and meaningful flows of people, money, labor, goods, information, advice, care, and love" (Sánchez, 2007, p. 493). A key construct here is *simultaneity*; that is, the experience and construction of a life that incorporates institutions, routines, and activities across national borders (Levitt & Glick Schiller, 2004). Simultaneity sheds light on how migrants' learning of a new language and maintenance of connections to homeland networks can occur simultaneously and reinforce one another. A transnational stance implies a break with the view of migration as a one-way, unilinear process of assimilation. This transnational lens complicates "the grand narrative" of immigrant assimilation, the hallmark of which is the replacement of the heritage language, by illuminating how the incorporation of individuals into nation-states *and* the maintenance of transnational connections are not contradictory (Levitt & Glick Schiller, 2004). Past work on transnationalism has tended to highlight how groups maintain cohesion and construct lives across and within two or more nation-states. In turn, this article examines how simultaneity plays out within the language and family life of three sisters in everyday interactions at home in the United States. This case study sharpens our understanding of how transnationally circulating discourses and ideologies of language, and language learning in particular, shape family language practices as well as children's ascribed and prescribed identities within one transnational family. Though the stated family language policy goal was bilingualism for all three daughters, the data here illustrate how Ecuadorian and U.S. ideologies of language learning differentially frame the girls' experiences and constrain their identities, roles, and future language use and competencies.

RESEARCH CONTEXT

The Ecuadorian family profiled here experienced their decisions to migrate to the United States as individual and personal; yet their moves were also part of a pronounced trend that swept Ecuador in the 1990s, what Jokisch and Pribilsky (2002) described as the "panic to leave" (p. 75). The first member of the family to migrate, the father (Miguel), arrived in 1992, as part of the initial wave of outgoing migrants. Prior to 1990, few Ecuadorians had ever crossed nation-state borders for work. A decade later, more than a quarter of a million Ecuadorians emigrated in 2 years alone (1999–2000). This panic coincided with overlapping political and economic crises, including a border war with Peru, the El Niño floods, declining oil prices, and a public loss of confidence in half a dozen presidents (Gallegos, 2000; Lucero, 2001). These events culminated in a severe economic downturn in 1999, accompanied by austere corrective measures and high inflation. As standards of living fell sharply, opportunities abroad were perceived as increasingly attractive or necessary (Miles, 2004). For instance, wages for manual work were more than 10 times greater abroad than in Ecuador in 2001 ($3.00 an hour vs. $2.00 to $3.00 per day).

Although Spain was the most common destination, many Ecuadorians aspired to migrate to the United States, a notion reinforced by the frequent (although statistically questionable) media claims in Ecuador that there are "more than a million" Ecuadorians in the United States

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(Jokisch & Pribilsky, 2002, p. 78). Because an unknown number of Ecuadorians are undocumented, accurate figures do not exist. Best estimates suggest that there are between 550,000 and 600,000 Ecuadorians in the United States (Migration Policy Institute, 2007). Within Minnesota, the site of the present study, Ecuadorian migration dates back nearly forty years, with the population increasing dramatically around 2000 (Moreno & Panchi Vaca, 2008). There are now 20,000 to 25,000 Ecuadorians in Minnesota, most in the Twin Cities (Minneapolis–St. Paul) area. An estimated 75% are here without authorization (J. Moreno, personal communication, September 30, 2008).

Ecuador is defined by its geographic and linguistic diversity. For instance, although the population numbers only 14 million, there are 13 Indigenous languages spoken across three distinct geographic areas. This diversity is reflected among Ecuadorians in Minnesota as well. Although many Ecuadorians are from the central Andean highlands, the Ecuadorian community is self-described as noncohesive and often in oppositional terms (e.g., "Latinos who are not Mexican"). Ecuadorians in the Twin Cities are geographically dispersed and attend one or more of a half dozen Catholic or Evangelical churches. Both Indigenous and non-Indigenous Ecuadorians tend to identify by region of origin rather than by nationality. Only partly in jest, the former president of the Ecuadorian Civil Committee in Minneapolis described his role as "the head of an organization without a body" (J. Panchi Vaca, personal communication, November 20, 2008).

THE STUDY

Data were collected over 14 months through weekly home visits that included participant observation, informal interviews with family members, and family-generated audio-recordings of home conversations. These 45- to 90-minute visits allowed for observations of family interactional patterns and informal conversations. Close analysis of transcribed family interactions and interviews examined how each of the three daughters, aged 1, 12, and 17, was positioned and positioned herself discursively as a language learner and user and how ideologies about language learning shaped the ways in which identities and family roles were constructed and enacted.

Initially, weekly visits began as homework sessions help for the oldest daughter, Diana. During these Fall 2008 meetings, Diana and I spoke mostly in Spanish about school life, friendships, and life in Ecuador and Minneapolis. Most weeks, I helped her with specific class assignments; other days, we worked on general English language skills. By January 2009, visits were more integrated with family activities. I chatted with all members of the family and was often asked to translate letters or negotiate administrative tasks (e.g., state health insurance forms) by phone or in person with the family.

Roughly half of these weekly sessions were audio-recorded. These recordings included informal interviews and discussions, as well as spontaneous interactions between family members while I was in another part of the house. In addition, the family self-recorded home interactions throughout the year with a small digital recorder. Recordings were transcribed by a Spanish–English bilingual research assistant, verified by the researcher, coded thematically, and analyzed using ethnographically informed discourse analysis (De Fina, 2003). Specifically, traditional discourse analysis approaches (e.g., De Fina, 2003) were used to examine interactions among family members (e.g., patterns of language choice, narratives, argumentation); this analysis was

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informed by insights gleaned from informal observations and interviews over the data collection period. Interviews were approached as settings ripe for construction of identities and the management of personal relations (De Fina, Schiffrin, & Bamberg, 2006). This analysis approach meant that the interviews, like all talk, were treated as an interactional occasion in which participants share personal knowledge and experiences and position themselves relative to such content through their linguistic and discursive choices (King & De Fina, 2010).

One Family, Two Homes, Three Sisters

Like many (im)migrant families, the migration story of the Llapa-Macas family has multiple stages. Miguel and Gloria met and married in Ecuador in 1990; their first daughter, Diana, was born in 1991. With few prospects for steady income in Ecuador, Miguel came to Minneapolis in 1992, arriving undocumented and alone, knowing one Ecuadorian who rented him a room. Miguel worked in construction and restaurants, and Gloria joined him in 1994, leaving Diana in the care of her parents (Diana's grandparents) in Guayaquil. In 1998, Gloria and Miguel gave birth to a second daughter, Debbie, in Minneapolis. After years of paperwork and delays, Gloria and Miguel were able to legalize their immigration status and filed paperwork to bring Diana to the United States. In 2003, Diana was granted legal residency. By then, she was 14 and had been living with her grandparents for more than 10 years, having only seen her parents twice in Ecuador. In 2004, Gloria, Debbie, and Miguel visited Ecuador to finalize arrangements for Diana's move to the United States, and Diana arrived midway through her sophomore high school year in 2006. Gloria then became pregnant with their third girl, Daniela, born in September 2008. Gloria quit her job in food preparation to care for the baby. Miguel continued working at two restaurants, taking as many hours offered. The study began in October of 2008, when Debbie was attending third grade, Diana was in her senior year of high school, and Daniela was an infant.

Gloria

Though this basic chronology outlines some of the major events of collective family life, it tells us nothing about how these events were differentially experienced. For instance, Gloria's experience of immigration is colored by her unhappy marriage. For the duration of the study, Gloria was critically (re)evaluating her relationship with Miguel, and her reflections on migration decisions were intertwined with her evaluations of her marriage. Across many family conversations, migration was framed in multiple ways: as a trick played by Miguel when he initially left for the United States; as a threat by Gloria to return to Ecuador with the girls; and as evident below, between the older two girls, as a means to provoke anxiety. Despite this turmoil, Gloria was a strong maternal presence. She was very concerned that the girls do well in school, keeping close tabs on their time and activities. Gloria's most frequently and forcefully expressed concern for Diana was that she study (at home) and acquire English quickly, a point of ongoing tension. As we see below, this tension was compounded by the fact that each of the girls has had varied opportunities for learning and using Spanish and English and has faced differing ideologically shaped expectations with respect to language.

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Diana

Although Diana arrived in the United States at age 16 with no English skills, Gloria believed that English language learning would be quick and easy for her. Gloria reported that she had expected Diana to be fluent in English within a year. Gloria's notions of second language learning were based partly on the experiences of her second daughter, Debbie, who learned English with little observed effort. They also corresponded to broadly circulating ideologies on the supposed speed and ease of second language learning (e.g., Tse, 2001), particularly for child language learners (Marinova-Todd, Marshall, & Snow, 2000).

Diana attended a high school in north Minneapolis for 6 months, where she mostly had English as second language (ESL) coursework. Her mother transferred her to high school in south Minneapolis for her junior year, because Gloria felt that Diana would learn English more quickly at a high school with fewer Spanish-speaking peers. By her junior year, Diana was taking a mix of ESL and mainstream (non-college-prep) coursework and by senior year was taking only one ESL course. Gloria asked me to tutor Diana because she was anxious about Diana's perceived slow progress in English. Gloria wanted extra help for Diana but was also protective and suspicious of school-based, extracurricular activities and thus preferred that she come home immediately after school.

Although Diana's English skills were sufficient for her to comprehend uncomplicated, contextualized texts, they did not allow her to fully engage with non-ESL class assignments. For instance, many high-frequency academic vocabulary words seemed unfamiliar to her (e.g., *increase*, *value*, *growth*). Her written work revealed that she was still acquiring basic grammatical sequences, such as question formation. As the year wore on, Gloria became increasingly vocal about her frustrations with what she perceived to be Diana's slow progress in learning English and her lack of effort. For Gloria, both the cause and evidence were Diana's reluctance to use English at home and, in particular, her refusal to practice with her sister Debbie.

Diana graduated from high school in May of 2009 with a 3.0 grade point average. Because she had been in Minnesota for fewer than 3 years, she was exempt from state graduation testing requirements. Nevertheless, her English skills were not strong enough to enroll in regular (that is, for-credit, nonremedial, non-ESL) junior college coursework. Although she took the placement tests three times, her scores required her to enter into intermediate-level ESL. The counselor estimated that she would need three semesters of pre-college ESL. This was a huge disappointment to Diana and her parents and was compounded by news that Diana was ineligible for financial aid based on her parents' 2008 income. By June 2009, Diana was employed full-time at the deli where her father worked. Though Diana still talked of studying to become a nurse, she frequently mentioned returning to Ecuador, feeling like she did not belong in the United States and aware of an anti-Latino bias. Meanwhile, as evident in Excerpt 1 below, Gloria was still urging Diana to practice English:

Excerpt 1 (August 16, 2009)[1]

01 Kendall So you speak English with? You said last time just with the *meseros*?
02 To anyone else you speak English to?
03 Dianao [oh.

[1]See appendix for transcription conventions.

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04 Kendall [no?
05 Gloria You speak English. You need to practice.
06 Diana *No, dice que si practico con los meseros.*
07 Gloria You need to practice (.) *pero que practiques con los meseros digo*
08 *yo. porque uno no se aprende.*
01 Kendall So you speak English with? You said last time just with the waiters?
02 To anyone else you speak English to?
03 Diana O[oh.
04 Kendall [don't you?
05 Gloria You speak English. You need to practice.
06 Diana No, she says if I practice ((English)) with the waiters.
07 Gloria You need to practice (.) but you need to practice with the waiters,
08 I say. Because one alone does not learn.

Gloria was direct and repetitive in encouraging her daughter to use English. Diana often seemed to resent and resist this pressure, complaining bitterly when her mother was out of earshot, for instance, that she was required to study at home and not permitted to attend after-school activities. Despite Diana's progress in acquiring English and mastering many aspects of a new social and academic system, she was still framed as unsuccessful by her parents, and her mother in particular, who felt that she should be a fully proficient speaker. As her mother expressed more than once (here, June 4, 2008), "*Ya tiene más que dos años acá. Debe hablar bién*." ("She's already been here for more than two years. She should speak well.") Here, the expectation that language learning will be quick and easy sets Diana up to experience failure and disappointment both at school and home (see Okita, 2001). These ideologically formed expectations of language learning not only shaped how Diana was constructed in the family—as unsuccessful and uncommitted—but also shaped the interactions between Diana and her sister, Debbie.

Debbie

Debbie's experiences with English language learning also framed expectations for her older sister, Diana. Gloria reported that Debbie learned English very quickly in day care and school and that English has always been her stronger language. Debbie was never enrolled in ESL and by her own and her parents' accounts was a strong student. Yet though Debbie was the most balanced bilingual in her family, her language identity and competencies were also negatively framed by ideologies of language and, specifically, by the notion of the balanced bilingual. And although Debbie's Spanish was fluent, Debbie's Spanish was a source of teasing within the immediate and extended family. In societal monolingual contexts, bilinguals are often expected to perform as "two monolinguals in one person" (Baker, 2006, p. 10); that is, with proficiency equal to that of a monolingual in both of their languages. When bilinguals are perceived to fail to meet this exacting standard, their language, intellect, or education are deemed inferior (MacSwan & Rolstad, 2008).

For Debbie, this monolingual perspective of bilingualism meant that despite her English being regularly praised, her Spanish was a source of ridicule. She was often teased by her immediate family for mispronouncing Spanish words and by her extended family in Ecuador, with whom she spoke multiple times each week by phone, as sounding like a *serrana* (here meaning an [Indigenous] highlander with Quichua-influenced Spanish) or like *La India María*,

a Mexican comedian who poses as a Spanish-as-a-second-language speaker to comic effect. Debbie frequently mentioned her perceived inadequacies in Spanish as well, often linking these Spanish-language inadequacies with her identity as an American (Excerpt 2).

Excerpt 2 (August 6, 2009)

01	Kendall	*¿Y tu sientas más americana?*
02	Debbie	((nods yes)) *Porque cuando hablo español dice que hablo como una*
03		*serrana.*
01	Kendall	And do you feel more American?
02	Debbie	((nods yes)) Because when I speak Spanish (people) say that I speak like
03		a serrana.

Debbie also cited her Spanish skills as a reason for not wanting to return to Ecuador. She felt that she would not be prepared to participate in school and would be laughed at for her accent.

These perceived Spanish-language shortcomings were also framed by Debbie and her family in favorable terms, as if speaking Spanish less than perfectly elevated and made permanent her status within the United States. The ideologically powerful association between speaking good English and being a good U.S. citizen (Haviland, 2003) at least partially explains the familial pride in Debbie's English. She frequently was held up to her older sister as a model of language learning success. However, over time, this evolved into a source of tension as each girl's familial role was defined through language competency. Gloria was insistent that Diana practice English with Debbie and often was exasperated that Diana refused to learn from Debbie. Diana complained that as the older sister she did not want to be corrected by Debbie and, in turn, Diana teased Debbie about her less-than-native Spanish. Aspects of this dynamic are evident in Excerpt 3, in which Debbie, Diana, and I are discussing the possibility of returning to Ecuador. Debbie is excited by the prospect of celebrating Daniela's first birthday with her extended family in Ecuador.

Excerpt 3 (August 6, 2009)

01	Debbie	Celebrate it over there with grandmothers, cousins, aunties, uncles. And
02		I'm taking extra money to buy things for me over there [in Ecuador].
03	Diana	@
04	Debbie	and umm things to buy for my grandma, like food.
05	Diana	but you know how man (.) she have only XXX in the bank
06	Debbie	Six hundred.
07	Kendall	You have six hundred dollars?
08	Debbie	Yeah (.) and thirty six cents.
09	Kendall	Wow, that's a lot of money! How did you save that much money?!
10	Debbie	Since I was a little girl.
11	Kendall	Anytime they gave you money to save it?
12	Debbie	I find in my house, in the vending machines over there. ((gestures towards
13		the park and community center across the street)) You know like in the
14		ground,
15	Kendall	Aha.
16	Diana	No! she find it all in the house when my dad pour it in the xxx!
17	Kendall	@

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18	Debbie	No!
19	Diana	*yeah. Si cuan[do*
20	Debbie	*[Tú ahorita eso!, pero cuando era chiquita no!, tú no*
21		*sab[es!*
22	Diana	*[Me parece que tu [xxx.*
23	Debbie	[You don't know!
24	Diana	*Tenías un poc[o*
25	Debbie	[English! @
18	Debbie	NO!
19	Diana	yeah. Yes, wh[en
20	Debbie	[you, now this!, but when I was a little girl no!, you don't
21		kn[ow,!
22	Diana	[It seems to me [xxx.
23	Debbie	[You don't know!
24	Diana	You had a little b[it.
25	Debbie	[English! @

Highly salient here is how language choice becomes a way of negotiating footing (Goffman, 1981). Debbie is proud to report that she has saved $600 by collecting small change. In her telling, she emphasizes that she scavenged resourcefully for coins (lines 12–14). Diana contradicts Debbie, claiming that she only has picked up her father's pocket change around the house (line 16). Debbie rejects this, and Diana reasserts her claim, this time in Spanish (line 19). The playful exchange in English turns more serious as Diana's use of Spanish evokes her big sister, authoritative role and Debbie seems to feel that her veracity and character are challenged. In Goffman's (1981) terms, her "posture" or "projected self" is at stake. Debbie attempts to undermine Diana's claim to authority in lines 20–21 by talking privately to her and pointing to the fact that when Diana was young, she did not know what was happening (because she was in Ecuador). Debbie is animated and agitated in this turn, evident in her rate of speech and strength of voice. Diana attempts to deescalate the exchange by being less assertive, starting her next turn with "*me parece que*" ("it seems to me") in line 22. Debbie interrupts her in English despite Diana's use of Spanish in her previous turn, stating emphatically, "You don't know" (line 23). When Diana again tries to prove her point in Spanish that not all of the money was found in vending machines, Debbie cuts her off and triumphantly closes the topic with the assertion that English should be used (line 25).

This excerpt illustrates how language competencies and the ideologically informed expectations surrounding these competencies are used strategically in the negotiation of footing and shape sibling interactions. Spanish does not necessarily index an Ecuadorian identity and English an American one; rather, "each code has multiple meanings"; these meanings vary according to the speaker, the social context, and the dynamics of that particular moment of the conversation (Fuller, 2007, p. 127). The conversation is shaded by the parental expectation that Diana should know English by now *and* that English should be used between the girls. Language choice is used to strengthen each sister's position and assert dominance. Diana attempts to make her points in Spanish, in part because this is her stronger language but also because she perceives Spanish use as putting Debbie on weaker ground in terms of argumentative capacity. Debbie uses Spanish to attempt to silence Diana by reminding her of her latecomer status to the family. When this fails,

she then uses English to state strongly, "You don't know." And when this fails, Debbie makes language choice rules explicit, capitalizing on the expectation that Diana should use English and that she is the "expert" English speaker to silence Diana.

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Daniela

Though Diana's role in the family is influenced by ideologies of (rapid) second language learning and Debbie's by idealized notions of the balanced bilingual, Daniela's identity is shaped by the long-standing ideological link across race, nation, and language. This ideology, often traced back to writing of Herder (1784) and championed by Fishman (1972), positions the mother tongue as embodying and inextricably tied to national and racial identity. Though research and theory have rightly problematized Herdian discourses,[2] the one language–one nation concept remains potent as an ideological and discursive frame employed in everyday discourse (Blommaert, 1999).

Here, this ideological frame exerts such a strong influence that despite Daniela's near exclusive exposure to Spanish, she is routinely described—by her mother, sisters, and father—as the English-speaking, all-American, racially "White" addition to the family. Her status as the "miracle" or "dream" baby is enhanced by the fact that her parents tried for years for a third child. They attribute Daniela's conception to prayers made at the *Virgen Del Cisne* shrine in Ecuador in 2004. Both parents and sisters believe that Daniela has a strong preference for English. Gloria and Diana noted repeatedly that, from a few months of age, Daniela preferred English- to Spanish-language cartoons and preferred to be read to in English, listening intently to English-language stories but throwing down her Spanish-language books. Correspondingly, during Daniela's first year, most of her protolanguage was "richly interpreted" (Brown, 1973) as English (e.g., *mama* as *mine*, *ou-ou* as *out*). This tendency is evident in Excerpt 4, in which Debbie is singing and is trying to get Daniela (9 months) to dance.

Excerpt 4 (June 4, 2009)

01 Debbie *Baile baile Dani!* ((Singing: *I like to move it move it*))
02 Gloria *Vamos vamos!*
03 Daniela ((Babbling)) *ba-ba-ba*
04 Debbie ((Singing)) *I like to move it move it!*
05 Gloria [Cuidado! No te caigas!
06 Daniela Ba-ba-ba ((scooting in her walker))
07 Debbie She wants her bottle. *Dice* bottle.
01 Debbie Dance dance Dani! ((Singing: *I like to move it move it*))
02 Gloria let's go let's go!
03 Daniela ((Babbling)) ba-ba-ba
04 Debbie ((Singing)) *I like to move it move it!*
05 Gloria [Be careful! Don't fall!

[2]Most researchers now routinely reject these straightforward one-to-one correspondences between language and racial, ethnic, or national identity in favor of a "practice-based variation" approach (Mendoza-Denton, 2002, p. 489). Such an approach emphasizes the microdynamics of indexicality and how identity is variably constructed, negotiated, achieved, and performed.

06 Daniela Ba-ba-ba ((scooting in her walker))
07 Debbie She wants her bottle. She says bottle.

This exchange illustrates three important aspects of Daniela's language environment. The first is that most of the language directed to Daniela was Spanish; here we see the six commands ("dance", "dance", "let's go", "let's go", "careful", and "don't fall") in fewer than 30 seconds are all in Spanish. The second is ongoing, low-level or background presence of English, here in Debbie's lyrics but also in the music and television and Debbie's mixed English–Spanish language use. The third is that Daniela's own language is often interpreted as English (e.g., *ba-ba* as *bottle* and not *baile*).

This apparent contradiction—that is, between Daniela's perceived English language preferences/competencies and her Spanish language environment—can be linked to her constructed national and racial identity within the family as White and American. Evidence of this construction is apparent in Excerpt 5, in which we were discussing the neighborhood children who Gloria minded a few hours weekly. I asked whether the mother of the children was Mexican. Debbie responded playfully that the mom is a "White-y," which initiated a light-hearted conversation about racial identity.

Excerpt 5 (August 29, 2009)

01 Kendall *¿Es mexicana?* [the mother of the neighbor's children]
02 Debbie *Ella es huerita!*
03 Diana *si?*
04 @
05 Debbie *Y le dijeron donde nació tu mama, y dice aquí. Aquí? Digo, porque parece*
06 *de otro lugar.*
07 *(.)*
08 Kendall *Y tú? Tú naciste acá.*
09 Diana *Sí, pero ella no es huerita.*
10 Debbie *Soy latinaamericana!*
11 @
12 Kendall *Y Daniela?*
13 Debbie *Ella si es huerita!*
14 @
15 Kendall *¿Por qué Daniela es huerita?*
16 Debbie *No está no está quemada por el sol.*
17 Kendall *¿No es qué?*
18 Debbie *No esta quemada por el sol y tiene mucho de inglés que de español*
19 Kendall @
20 Diana *Le dices huerita-*
21 Debbie *Está blanca. No está quemada por el sol.*
01 Kendall Is [she] Mexican?
02 Debbie She is *huerita*!
03 Diana yes?
04 @
05 Debbie and they told [asked] her where her mom was born and she says here. Here? I

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06 say, because she looks like from another place.
07 (.)
08 Kendall And you? You were born here.
09 Diana Yes, but she is not *huerita*
10 Debbie I am Latinamerican!
11 @
12 Kendall and Daniela?
13 Debbie She is really *huerita*!
14 @
15 Kendall Why is Daniela *huerita*?
16 Debbie She is not sunburned.
17 Kendall She is not what?
18 Debbie She is not sunburned and she has more English than Spanish.
19 Kendall @
20 Diana You call her *huerita-*
21 Debbie She is White. She is not sunburned.

Here, Debbie defines herself as having been born here (in the United States) but as Latin American. Daniela, in turn, is "White-y," in part because of perceived differences in her skin color but also because of her ascribed English language competence (line 18). This perceived English preference and competence exists despite the fact that the vast majority of the language she hears around her and directed toward her is in Spanish. Daniela's national and racial identity within the family as White and American thus frames how her language competencies, preferences, and speech are interpreted. In a sense, her family is enacting the long-standing ideological link across language–nation–race that dates back more than 200 years but can also be traced to 20th-century developments in the United States. Very quickly, in just one generation, the link between national identity, English monolingualism, and a racialized White Anglo-Saxon norm was forged in the United States, and as bilingualism became unimaginable, "the hegemonic ideology of English monolingualism as a keystone of Americanness came to dominate public discourses" (Pavlenko, 2002, p. 192). This framing of Daniela as an English monolingual American is significant not only because it shapes how her infant language is interpreted but also because it determines her future language competencies.

DISCUSSION

This case study illustrates how ideologies of language, and of language learning in particular, shape the experience of three sisters within one transnational family. Close analysis of family talk reveals how specific ideologies manifest themselves within family interactions and in family understandings of themselves and each other. Such forces are most evident in Gloria's concern that Diana learn English quickly. These pressures translate into unrealistic expectations in light of second language acquisition research (Collier, 1989) and Diana's limited exposure to English prior to coming to the United States and in her first years in the country. The pervasive ideology that (English) language learning should be both quick and easy helps us understand Gloria's frustrations and actions, but these same ideologically shaped expectations leave Diana vulnerable to

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personal criticism and educational disappointment. Though Debbie is viewed as a success story within her family, ideologies of (idealized) bilingualism also shape the framing of Debbie's language skills. Both Debbie and her family expect that she should sound like a monolingual native Spanish speaker and monolingual native English speaker. This ideology, or the monolingual view of bilingualism (Baker, 2006) for Debbie is the source of anxiety and self-doubt. The case of Daniela reminds us of how sharply language identity can differ from language competence. Her story also points to how language identity can shape language competence; as the excerpt above suggests, the "rich interpretation" of early language sounds as English by caretakers can lead those caretakers to use English in response.

This case study also draws our attention to the varied language competencies within one generation of siblings. Though research with immigrant families in the United States indicates that children tend to be more dominant in English than their parents and that the eldest children often play a role in introducing English into the home (Hinton, 1999; Shin, 2005; Stevens & Ishizawa, 2007), within this transnational family, competencies are inverted with the middle and younger children as the instigators of English language shift. This case highlights how both language competencies and linguistic identities potentially vary within one generation of siblings. We saw how Diana was framed as the unsuccessful English language learner, Debbie as the problematic Spanish speaker but proficient English user, and Daniela as the English monolingual. These language identities within the home arise in part from perceptions of language competencies and preferences but are also the result of broadly circulating discourses and ideologies of languages. These ideologies not only serve as frames for interpreting past speech but also set the tone for future interactions. For instance, Diana, as the older sister, prefers to speak Spanish in the house in part because she feels vulnerable and inadequate when speaking in English; yet, at the same time, by not speaking Spanish, she confirms her mother's perceptions that she is not trying.

Models suggest that language shift prototypically takes place across three generations, with the second generation introducing the language into the home (e.g., Fishman, 1966), and abundant work points to the pivotal role of children in instigating [language shift in the home] this move (Baker, 2006). Past research focusing on siblings in bilingual households has stressed the role of first-born children in initiating language shift (Shin, 2005; Yamamoto, 2001), a trend supported by findings that elder siblings are effective instructors—for instance, providing more explanation and positive feedback—than matched non-siblings (Azmita & Hesser, 1993; Koester & Johnson, 1984). The transnational case presented here, in contrast, points to a divergent situation in which the eldest sibling is an anchor maintaining the heritage language, reminding us that the roles of siblings are much more varied and complicated than posited by previous studies of family language shift, which typically did not include transnational families such as this.

Finally, this case study complicates our views of the family and traditional approaches to assimilation and migration by pointing to the many and lasting connections that this family has with Ecuador. These connections with Ecuador are not past-oriented but present and future-oriented and also ripe with apparent contradictions. As an example, Gloria and Diana began studying for their U.S. citizenship in Fall 2009; their motivation was not the desire to become citizens but rather to be able to return to Ecuador easily and to bring Gloria's parents to the United States. And for Diana, graduating from high school has meant an end to her English language learning and future educational opportunity. And though Diana wished to return to Ecuador, by September 2009, what rooted Diana to the United States was her relationship with

her Ecuadorian boyfriend in Minneapolis. These deep connections—both real and imagined—to the United States and to Ecuador coincide and are mutually reinforcing.

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CONCLUSION

Debbie: *It's like the same. You don't feel the difference. You are just human. You feel anything. Like if I am American I can like Italian food. You feel Ecuadorian. I'm American. I can eat whatever.* (August 6, 2009)

Although this article has focused on language and identity practices among three girls over one year, these practices were just one aspect of their lives. Indeed, the family was deeply engaged with other, perhaps more important issues, such as roof repairs and disputes with the insurance company over damage, Miguel's reduction in hours and increased mortgage interest payments, and Gloria's fibroid surgery in February. Although the three sisters are neatly illustrative of three themes, there is no neat narrative here. Rather, the aim has been to provide "thematic threads, meaningful events and powerful factors that allow us entry into the multiple realities and dynamic processes" (Haas Dyson & Genishi, 2005, p. 111) constituting the everyday drama of language use and everyday life in transnational families. The older two girls and the mother were passionate and articulate in talking about language and migration and often discussed these issues with each other on tape among themselves and with me in conversation. Yet these affiliations and identities, both stated and felt, have already changed, and as Debbie suggested above, do not necessarily or permanently constrain behavior.

By late summer of 2009, Gloria and the girls were thinking seriously about returning to Ecuador. They had applied for and received Daniela's U.S. passport and were investigating flights and costs. This turn seemed prompted by tensions between Gloria and Miguel, along with a desire on the part of Gloria to return home to visit her parents and celebrate Daniela's first birthday with them. By late fall of 2009, Daniela's first birthday had been celebrated in Minneapolis with a small party of family and friends. Gloria continued to investigate ticket prices. Debbie had started school and was settled into the routines of fall semester. Diana was still working at the deli and talking about nursing school in Minneapolis but also about returning to Ecuador. And Gloria, while on the brink of filing for divorce during the summer, seemed to come to terms with her less than perfect marriage.

This study has examined how language learning and family identities are (re)configured in one transnational family. This case study offers a close picture of how broadly circulating ideologies of language and language learning impact family language practices. For educators, this study points to the importance of understanding potential variation between siblings as well as parental expectations of second language learning. In particular, this means taking care with assumptions about who is more proficient and being mindful that perceived language identity does not always correspond to actual language competences. The study is also a reminder that family migrations are often multistep and that pressures to use English can negatively impact family dynamics. In turn, for researchers, this case underlines the need to understand family assumptions and belief systems around language and language learning and also to do more to make public and widely available central research findings that have much to say about the pace and nature of second

language learning and bilingualism. More broadly, this work has illustrated the value of documenting and analyzing everyday family language practices because these mundane interactional mechanisms shed light on the impact and the enactment of broader circulating ideologies of language and language learning but also provide insights into the production of the next generation of transnational language users and speakers.

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APPENDIX: TRANSCRIPTION CONVENTIONS

Italics	*Spanish in original text*
CAPS	spoken with emphasis
.	at the end of words marks falling intonation
,	at the end of words marks slight rising intonation
–	abrupt cutoff, stammering quality when hyphenating syllables of a word
!	animated tone, not necessarily an exclamation
(.)	micro-pause
[	overlapping speech
(( ))	transcriber's comment or addition
@	laughter
XXX	unintelligible word
?	strong rising intonation at end of utterance